

Existential predicative possession: a subtype of non-canonical constructions in Western Iranian languages

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Outline of the talk

1. Iranian languages
2. Data
3. Predicative possession: an overview
4. Predicative possessive constructions in Iranian
 - be-possessives
 - have-possessives
 - co-occurrence of be-possessives and have-possessives
5. Areal distribution of 'be' and 'have'-possessives

Data

Mohammadirad (forth.): Pronominal clitics in Western Iranian languages

Descriptive grammars

Predicative possession

Possession: attributive, predicative

A relation of possession: a Possessor, a Possessee, a relator (e.g. genitive marker, a verb)

Stassen (2009) offers a classification of predicative possession based on parameters of '**permanent contact**' and '**control**'

Possessive subtype	Permanent contact	Control	Example
Alienable	+	+	<i>I have a car</i>
Inalienable	+	—	<i>John has a brother</i>
Temporary	—	+	<i>Look out! That guy has a knife</i>
Abstract	—	—	<i>Mary has a problem/ no time</i>

The domains of '**experience**' and '**age**' are distinguished from that of Abstract possession

Predicative possession: the range of syntactic structures (source schemas)

Schema	Syntactic structure
Action schema “X takes Y” > X has Y	PR: subject of a transitive predicate PE: object of a transitive predicate
Location schema “Y is located at X” > X has Y	PR: locative adjunct PE: subject of an existential predicate/locative copula
Companion schema a. “X is with Y” > X has Y	PR: subject of an existential predicate/copula PE: comitative adjunct
b. “Y is with X” > X has Y	PR: comitative adjunct PE: subject of an existential predicate/copula
Genitive schema “X’s Y exists” > X has Y	PR: genitival modifier of the PE PE: subject of an existential predicate
Goal schema “Y exists to/for X” > X has Y	PR: illative/dative or benefactive adjunct PE: subject of an existential predicate/copula
Topic schema “As for X, Y (of X) exists > X has Y	PR: clausal topic PE: subject of an existential predicate
Source schema “X exists away from Y” > X has Y	PR: ablative adjunct PE: subject of an existential predicate
Equation schema “Y is X’s property	PR: is in the genitive/dative case PE: subject of an existential predicate

Source schemas used for the expression of possession (Heine 1997: 47)

Predicative possession: Source schemas

Example:

Modern Danish ‘have’ is derived from old Norse *hefja* ‘take’, representing an example of the derivation of possession from ‘action schema’:

- (1) *han* *havde* *to* *biler*
 3SG.M.NOM have.PST.3SG two car
 ‘He had two cars’ (Mazzitelli 2017: 9, citing Allan et al. 2000: 111)

Possession split

Possession split : this term refers to cases where a language employs a different encoding strategy for some subtypes of possession.

E.g. Icelandic

- 2) a. *ert-u* *með* *lykilinn* *herra* *minn*
 be.2SG-you with key.def.acc sir my
 ‘Do you have the key, Sir?’

- b. *Dursley-hjón-in* *á-tt-u* *lítinn* *dreng*
 Dursley-couple-def have-pst-3pl little:acc boy
 ‘The Dursleys had a little son’. (Stolz et al. 2008: 27)

Predicative possession in Iranian: 'be'-possessives

Old Iranain

- 3) *Dârayava[h]auš* *pausâ* *anīyaičiy* *ahantâ*
 PN.GEN.M.SG son.NOM.M.PL other.NOM.M.PL exist.3PL.IPFV.MID
 'Darius had other sons.' (lit. 'Darius, other sons existed.')
- (Old Persian, Kent 1953:95, XPf 28f)

- 4) *nōit* *mē* *asti*
 neg 1sg.dat cop.prs.3sg
 'I have no' (Young Avestan, Skiærvø 2003: 18)

Predicative possession in Iranian: 'be'-possessives

Middle Iranian

- 5) *ēn zan, kē = š yak pus ast*
 this woman who = 3SG a son exist.PRS
 'This woman, to whom a son exists.' (Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 371, paT. 707)
- 6) *ērân-šahr dōsad-û čehel kadag-xwadây būd*
 Iran-city twohundred-and forty landlord exist.PST
 'Iran had two hundred forty landlords.' (Durkin-Meisterernst 2014:371, mpB. 708)

Predicative possession in Iranian: 'be'-possessives

Middle Iranian

- 7) *Pâbag* *rây* *êč* *farzand...* *nê* *bûd*
PN for any child NEG COP.PST

'Pâbag had no child.' (Paul 2008: 331, glossing modified)

Predicative possession in Iranian: 'be'-possessives

Modern languages: The syntactic structures of earlier stages recur.

Topicalized possessor

- 8) *naqlakē* *hakim-ak-ī* *sē* *kur* *habô-n*
 at.a.time prince-INDF-OBL three son exist.PST-PL

'Once a prince had three sons' (lit. once to-a-prince three sons existed) (Badini Kurdish, Haig 2008:258, citing MacKenzie 1962: 320, glossing modified)

Predicative possession in Iranian: 'be'-possessives

Modern languages

Possessor is the genitival modifier of the possessee

- 9) *du pişîk-ên min he-ne*
 two cat-EZ.PL 1SG.OBL exist-3PL
 'I have two cats.' (Kurmanji Kurdish)
- 10) *bāx-ê = ş ha-n*
 garden-PL.DIR = 3SG exist.PRS.3PL
 'He has (some) gardens.' (Hawrami Takht)
- 11) *o = mu ya xar-i bi*
 PTC = 1PL a donkey-INDF COP.PST
 'We had a donkey.' (Davani)
- 12) *yeki dot oş = bode*
 one girl 3SG = COP.PST
 'She had a daughter.' (lit. a daughter exists to her) (Bastaki)

Predicative possession in Iranian: 'be'-possessives

Modern languages

Possessor is the adjunct

- 13) *uu-ro yak pisar bud*
 3SG-for a boy COP.PST

'He had a son.' (Classical Tajik, Heine 1997: 61)

- 14) *i-la merdi-rā karg-i hest-be*
 a-CLF man-for hen-INDF exist-COP.PST

'A man had a hen.' (Lit. there existed a hen for a man) (Central Taleshi)

Predicative possession in Iranian: ‘be’-possessives

source schema	syntactic structure	languages
Topic schema “As for X, Y (of X)” exists	PR: clausal topic PE: subject of an existential predicate	Old Iranian, Middle Iranian, Badini
Genitive schema “X’s Y exists” > X has Y	PR: genitival free modifier of the PE PE: subject of an existential predicate	Kurmanji, Zazaki,
	PR: genitival bound modifier of the PE PE: subject of an existential predicate	Central Kurdish, Hawrami, Behbahani, Davani, Nowdani, Dashti, Delvari, Lari, Bastaki, Bandari, Minabi
Goal schema “Y exists to/for X”	PR: illative/dative or benefactive adjunct PE: subject of an existential predicate/copula	Middle Persian, Early New Persian, Classical Tajik, Central Taleshi

- Languages differ in the syntactic structures through which possessive relation is expressed.
- Existential/copular stem is used to establish all possessive notions.

Predicative possession in Iranian: 'have'-possessives

Old Iranian: the verb meaning 'hold' *dâr-*: transitive verb

- 15) *kâra* *haya* *Naditabair-ahayâ* *Tigr-âm* *a-dâraya*
 army of Naditabair-GEN Tigr-ACC IPFV-hold.3SG
 'The army of Nidintu-Bel held the Tigris.' (Kent 1953: 96, DB 1.85)

- 16) *ima* *xšaça-am* *tya* *adam* *dâray-âmi*
 this empire-ACC which 1SG.NOM hold-1SG
 'This is the empire which I hold.' (Kent 1953: 136, DPh 4-5)

Predicative possession in Iranian: ‘have’-possessives

Middle Iranian

The verb meaning ‘hold’ acquired the meaning ‘have’ as well

- 17) *ud frawardag pad dast dâr-ênd*
 and letter in hand have.PRS-3PL

‘And they have a letter in hand.’ (Middle Persian, Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 371, mpB. 711)

- 18) *u = š was zanag dâmag und wißandag dird*
 PTC = 3SG many rampant trap and snare have.PST

‘And he (a hunter) had many traps and snares.’ (Parthian, Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 371, paT. 709)

Predicative possession in Iranian: ‘have’-possessives

Modern languages: the verb meaning ‘hold’ totally reinterpreted as ‘have’

- **Alienable**

- 19) *unâ ye mâšin dâr-an*
 3PL a car have.PRS-3PL
 ‘They have a car.’ (colloquial Persian)

- **Inalienable**

- 20) *xwar-i dâr-am*
 sister-INDF have.PRS-1SG
 ‘I have a sister.’ (Luri, Amān Allāhi & Thackston 1986: 153)

- **Part-whole**

- 21) *miz çâhâr pâyê dâr-ad*
 table four leg have.PRS-3SG
 ‘(A) table has four legs.’ (Persian)

- **Abstract**

- 22) *mi kêr dâr-î*
 1SG task have.PRS-2SG
 ‘I have a task.’ (Hawrami Qal’eh)

Predicative possession in Iranian: Relics of older 'be' in have-possessive languages

i) Physical sensations

23) *sārmā = m-ā*

cold = 1SG-COP.3SG

'I'm cold.' (Zoroastrian dialect of Yazd)

24) *gwisna-(a)s = ī* *tišna-(a)s = ī*

hungry-COP.3SG = 3SG thirsty-COP.3SG = 3SG

'She is hungry (and) thirsty' (Laki Harsini, Belelli 2016: 120)

Predicative possession in Iranian: Relics of older 'be' in have-possessive languages

ii) 'age'

25) *por=i čan sāl=eš-e?*
 son = 2SG how.many year = 3SG-COP.3SG
 'How old is your son?' (Chali)

26) *si sāl=em bo*
 thirty year = 1SG COP.PST
 'I was thirty years old.' (Meymei)

but:

27) *ta pīr čon sāl-i dâr-e?*
 2SG.OBL son howmany year-OBL have.PRS-3SG
 'How old is your son?'

'Have'-possessive languages

- ❖ 'Have' is the product of reinterpretation and grammaticalization of the verb meaning 'hold'.
- ❖ 'have' is a regular transitive verb, which assigns subject properties to the possessor and object properties to the possessee
- ❖ Most 'have'-languages exhibit a relic of older 'be'-possessive in the domains of 'physical sensations' and 'age', hence possession split.

'be'-possessive and 'have'-possessive co-occur

i) Bijar Southern Kurdish (Garusi)

'be'-possessive with instances of inalienable possession

28) *kor = î nî-yu*

son = 3SG NEG-COP.PST

'(The king) didn't have (a) son.'

29) *dâr galâ = y dû*

tree leaf = 3SG COP.PRS.3SG

'The tree will have leaves.'

30) *bizn-a îşî şîr = im nî-ya*

goat-DEF say.PRS.3SG milk = 1SG NEG-exist.PRS

'The goat says: "I don't have milk".'

‘be’-possessive and ‘have’-possessive co-occur

i) Southern Kurdish (Garusi dialect)

‘have’-possessive with instance of alienable possession and abstract possession

- 31) *îme kewş n-eyr-îmân*
 1PL shoes NEG-have.PRS.1PL
 ‘We don’t have shoes.’

- 32) *min kêr dîr-im badbaxtî dîr-im*
 1SG task have.PRS-1SG problem have.PRS-1SG
 ‘I have a task (to do), I have a problem.’

- 33) *îma sawâd dîr-îmân*
 1PL literacy have.PRS-1SG
 ‘We have literacy.’

'be'-possessive and 'have'-possessive co-occur

ii) Sivandi

'be'-possessive with instances of inalienable possession

- 34) *ye pâdešâh-î bî ye kor-î=š bî*
 a king-INDF COP.PST a son-INDF = 3SG COP.PST

'There was a king, who had a son.'

- 35) *î ke čaš=eš bi-yân*
 DEM who eye= 3SG COP.PST-3PL?

'The one who had eyes (= who could see).' (Lecoq 1979: 160)

'be'-possessive and 'have'-possessive co-occur

ii) Sivandi

'have'-possessive with instances of alienable possession

- 36) *vali kolepošti dêr-e na jâme dêr-e*
 but haversack have.PRS-3SG NEG cup have.PRS-3SG
 'But he has the haversack, not the cup.' (Lecoq 1979: 95)

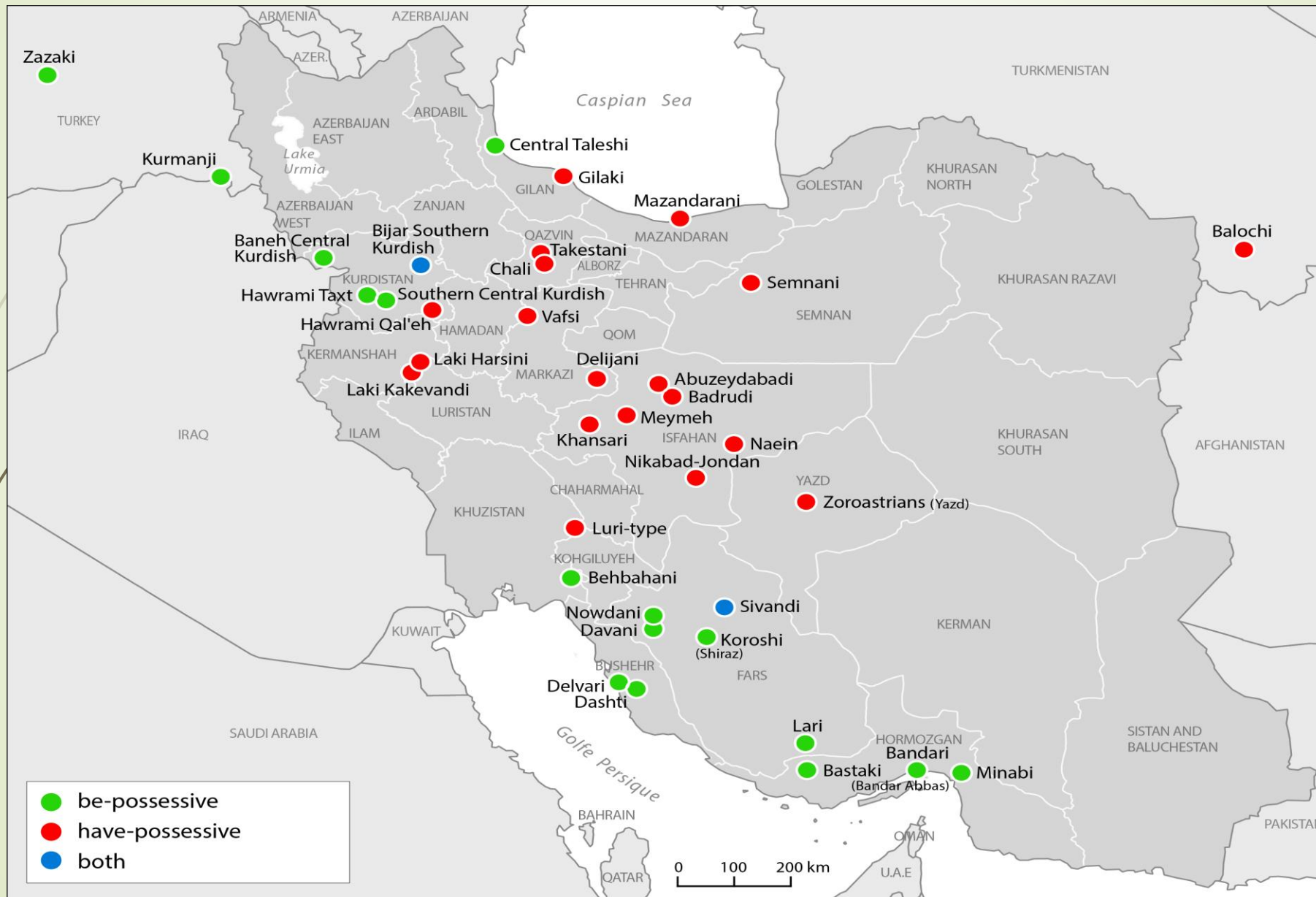
- 37) *hiç ra-î ham na-dar-e*
 no way-INDF too NEG-have.PRS-3SG
 'He has no options neither.' (own data)

'be'-possessive and 'have'-possessive co-occur

- These two languages clearly exhibit instances of possession split triggered by the nature of possessive relation, roughly corresponding to inalienability vs. alienability distinction.

Predicative possessive constructions in WILs

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Key points

- ❖ Predicative possessive constructions in Iranian: Two main types: (i) 'be'-possessive; (ii) have-possessive
- ❖ 'be'-possessive are based on the existential/copular stem and are more archaic than 'have'-possessives
- ❖ The verb meaning 'have' was the result of the grammaticalization of the verb meaning 'hold'
- ❖ A reflex of 'be'-possessive is traceable in have-languages (domains of 'physical sensations' and 'age')
- ❖ In two languages, 'be'-possessives and 'have'-possessives co-occur: these languages exhibit the existence of split possession (approximately) along alienability lines.